

Seawall height in Miami Beach

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

MIAMI BEACH • MIAMI-DADE COUNTY

5.7

 ft NAVD88

Required for a new seawall, or an existing one undergoing substantial improvement. A wall being repaired below that threshold may be built to 4.0 ft NAVD88, but only if it is designed and constructed to accommodate a future 5.7 ft.

The detail

INTERIM ELEVATION	4.0 ft NAVD88, allowed only for repairs that are less than substantial, and only if the wall is built to accommodate a future 5.7 ft.
WHAT COUNTS AS SUBSTANTIAL	Repairs costing \$500 or more per linear foot. Sec. 54-61, as amended by Ordinance 2025-4754 in July 2025.
DATUM	NAVD88 — the North American Vertical Datum of 1988. A figure quoted in MLW is not the same number.
CURRENT ORDINANCE	2025-4754, adopted 23 July 2025, amending Chapter 54, Article III.
THE MAINTENANCE CLOCK	60 days to show progress, 6 months to file permit applications with both the city and the county, 730 days to complete.
THE FINES	\$250 for a first offence, then \$500 per day.
TWO PERMITS, NOT ONE	City applications and Miami-Dade RER-DERM both have to be filed.

Where this comes from: City of Miami Beach Code Sec. 54-62(a); Ordinance 2025-4754, adopted 23 July 2025; City of Miami Beach maintenance and enforcement provisions

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1

Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2

Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3

Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4

Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.